UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

ENGL 1405-01 - AY2027-T1

Unit 8 Assignment

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The Evolution of Prose Writing and the Importance of Inclusivity

From Novels to Micro-Fiction

Prose writing has evolved through different forms that allow writers to communicate human experiences in different ways. Novels provide space for complex characters, detailed settings, and multiple storylines. Short stories focus more closely on events or conflicts, while micro-fiction presents meaningful narratives in an extremely limited number of words. These forms continue to coexist, demonstrating that literature can communicate powerful ideas through both extended narratives and concise storytelling.

According to Towell (2014), micro-fiction is generally understood as a very short form of flash fiction, often containing approximately 300 words or fewer. Its effectiveness depends on carefully selected details, focused on storytelling, and the ability to suggest meanings beyond what is explicitly written. Unlike a novel, which can explain a character's background and development extensively, micro-fiction challenges readers to interpret what the writer leaves unstated. This makes brevity an artistic choice rather than simply a reduction in length.

A useful example is A. M. Homes's *with One Wheel Gone Wrong*, included in the assigned Oprah.com collection. The story follows a shopper who becomes captivated by an idealized image of a house in a magazine. She imagines entering that picture and discovering the life she believes she should have. Her experience highlights

how advertising can influence personal desires and encourage people to pursue unrealistic ideals (Homes, 2006). The ordinary setting, imaginative transformation, and return to the checkout line create a compact narrative that invites readers to question consumer culture. The story demonstrates how a brief piece can suggest a much larger social issue without developing an extensive plot.

Micro-fiction also depends on implication and emotional precision. In *Sing to It*, Amy Hempel explores the difficulty of comforting another person through carefully controlled language and the tension between metaphors and emotional connection (Hempel, 2019). The concise narrative illustrates how a few exchanges can communicate vulnerability, affection, and the limits of language. Such writing supports Towell's (2014) argument that micro-fiction requires writers to identify essential details and remove unnecessary explanations. Therefore, the movement from novels to short stories and micro-fiction represents an expansion of literary possibilities, not the disappearance of traditional forms.

Inclusivity, Diversity, and Cultural Awareness

Diversity, equity, and inclusion are related concepts with distinct meanings. Diversity refers to the presence of people with different backgrounds, identities, abilities, and perspectives. Equity means providing fair opportunities and appropriate support, while inclusion involves creating environments in which people feel respected and can participate meaningfully (McKinsey & Company, 2022). Multiculturalism complements these principles by recognizing cultural differences and considering how minority groups can maintain their identities while participating in society (Song, 2020).

These ideas are particularly important in education. Possi and Milinga (2017) examined learner diversity in inclusive classrooms and identified challenges involving language, gender, and disability. Their research suggests that placing different learners together does not automatically eliminate barriers to participation. Students may still need accessible materials, clear explanations, appropriate accommodations, and opportunities to contribute. Similarly, Evans (2017) emphasizes that people can improve relationships by examining their behavior and considering perspectives different from their own. Together, these sources demonstrate that inclusion requires both practical support and respectful communication.

Studying literature from different cultures has helped me understand that people can experience similar emotions while interpreting the world through different cultural and personal backgrounds. Literature encourages readers to look beyond stereotypes and consider the experiences of others. Homes's story, for example, encourages reflection on how social expectations influence individual choices, while Hempel's concise narrative draws attention to vulnerability and the difficulty of expressing care. Although these stories explore different situations, both show how literary experiences can encourage readers to examine assumptions and human relationships.

I can apply these lessons in university classrooms, professional environments, and online communities. In group projects, I can listen to classmates with different communication styles, distribute opportunities to contribute fairly, and avoid judging people before understanding their circumstances. In online discussions, I can disagree respectfully and support my arguments with evidence rather than personal assumptions. I can also encourage inclusive learning by explaining technical concepts clearly and considering the needs of people with different levels of experience.

Finally, this assignment demonstrates the value of synthesis. McKinsey's explanation of equity, Possi and Milinga's classroom research, and Evans's communication framework approach inclusion from different perspectives. Connecting them reveals that an inclusive environment depends on fair opportunities, appropriate support, and a willingness to understand others. Ultimately, literature provides more than entertainment: it develops empathy, strengthens cultural awareness, and encourages people to apply respect and understanding in everyday life.

References

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